

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ K 9
♥ K Q 10 6
♦ 9 6 4
♣ 10 7 5 2

♠ A J 5 2

♥ 8 5 4

♦ A K J 3

♣ 8 4



♠ 10 7 4

♥ A J 3

♦ 10 8 5 2

♣ J 9 3

♠ Q 8 6 3

♥ 9 7 2

♦ Q 7

♣ A K Q 6

West	North	East	South
	1♦	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South

Lead: ♥K

It kinda makes you wish you'd bid 2NT after all doesn't it?

A jump to 2NT would not be a terrible bid. But it is more important to show your 4-card Major.

So you bid 1♠ instead. Partner raises to 2♠.

It's another case of **HE WHO KNOWS, GOES**. You know you have at least 26 points and 8 ♠s. Of course you trust that partner would not raise a suit you bid as responder with only 3 trumps. So you bid 4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥K. The defense takes the first three ♥ tricks, then switch to a ♣.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥K. The defense takes the first three ♥ tricks, then switch to a ♣.

Losers: ♠ ? : ♥ 3 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3?

At least the picture is clear. Very clear. You have no wiggle room left so you must bring in the ♠s without losing a trick. So West **MUST** have the ♠K. Therefore you assume West does hold the ♠K.

Suppose you lead the ♠Q. West will play his ♠K and force you to play dummy's ♠A. Then one of the defenders will win the third ♠ with the ♠10 or ♠9.

No, you only have one chance to make this contract - West must hold a doubleton ♠ K x. So you lead a **SMALL** ♠ from your hand and finesse dummy's ♠J. Then play the ♠A, dropping West's ♠K, then pull the last trump with the ♠Q.

The reason you must not lead the ♠Q is that West will always cover and that will force you to use two of your honors on one trick.

Since you would only have one more honor you'd be bound to lose a trick.

Board 2

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 9 8 4

♥ A 5

♦ 9 3

♣ Q J 10

♠ A 7 2

♥ Q J 3

♦ Q 8 6 2

♣ 9 6 4

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♠ 5 3

♥ 10 7 6 4 2

♦ A 7 5

♣ 7 5 3

♠ K 6

♥ K 9 8

♦ K J 10 4

♣ A K 8 2

West

North

East

South

2 ♠

2NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♠ Q

you can just figure out which Ace West has you can establish that suit first.

But you don't have to guess, there is a better way. West overcalled at the 2-level with a Queen-high suit and one outside Ace. THAT is bold. Surely he has at least a 6-card suit to justify that overcall. If so, then a simple hold-up will be worthwhile. So you let West hold the first trick, and when he leads another ♠ you win the ♠K in your hand. If West has a 6-card suit East is now void of ♠s.

Play ♦s to drive out the ♦A. If East has it he will not have another ♠ to force you with. If West has it he can force out your last ♠, but then won't have the ♥A for an entry. However the Aces are split - as long as West doesn't have both - you will establish 9 tricks.

Without the holdup you could still have made the contract, but only if you had established the ♥ winners first. That would have been a total guess.

With the holdup it didn't matter which red suit you established first.

With 17 points and a balanced hand you naturally open 1NT. West overcalls 2 ♠. Your partner then bids 2NT.

Your partner invited you to bid 3NT if you had 17 points, and you have 17 points. You trust your partner so you bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q.

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

This looks scary. Needing 5 more tricks means you are going to have to establish **BOTH** red suits. And with only two ♠ stoppers you have to hope West doesn't have both red Aces. If he does, you're down, so just assume that he only has one of them. Now if

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9 7 3

♥ A K 8 4

♦ 10 8

♣ A 10 3

♠ 5 4

♥ 10 9 6 3

♦ A K 9 2

♣ Q 8 5



♠ A

♥ Q J 7 2

♦ J 7 5 3

♣ K J 6 4

♠ K Q J 8 6 2

♥ 5

♦ Q 6 4

♣ 9 7 2

Don't even think twice. Just pass and wonder why the opponents aren't bidding.

North would play 2♠.

Click

South plays 2♠. West leads ♥A, then ♥K.

North plays 2♠. East leads ♥A, then ♥K.

Losers: ♠ 1/2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 3 : Total = 5/6

West

North

East

South

2♠

All Pass

2♠ by South

Lead: ♥A

you might as well take extra pains if you can do so without risk.

If West has both ♣A and ♣K you could save yourself 1 ♣ loser, but the odds are about 3 to 1 against that. Your best chance of making this contract is just to hold your ♠ losers to 1. With an expected 3-2 split there will not be a problem, but

So after you ruff the ♥K you do **NOT** play the ♠K. Instead you play a ♦ to dummy and lead a ♠ toward your honors. Your extra pains pay off when East plays the ♠A, which was a singleton.

If you had led your ♠K East would have won the ♠A and you would later have to give up a ♠ trick to West's ♠10.

It costs nothing to make a careful play. Most of the time it doesn't matter, but every now and again it pays off in a contract that couldn't be made without the careful play.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10

♥ 3

♦ K 10 9 6 2

♣ A J 9 4

♠ A K 9 8 6 5 3

♥ 6 2

♦ Q 4

♣ 5 2



♠ 4 2

♥ K Q 10

♦ A J 7 5 3

♣ Q 8 7

♠ 7

♥ A J 9 8 7 5 4

♦ 8

♣ K 10 6 3

West

North

East

South

3♥

All Pass

3♥ by South

Lead: ♠Q

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 1/2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 4 : Total = 6/7

You really really want to say 3♠. Here are three good reasons you shouldn't.

You have 9 ♥s between you. You may have only 7 ♠s. If you bid 3♠ partner may bid again. You haven't been doubled.

North would play 3♥.

Click

South plays 3♥. West leads the ♠Q.

South plays 3♥. West leads the ♠Q.

It turns out there was a fourth reason not to bid 3♠ - the opponents might lead the suit.

The ♠ lead is about the best thing that could have happened to you. You win with dummy's ♠A and play ♠K, discarding your ♦. You then lead a small ♣, covering anything East plays. You'd like to ruff a ♣ if you can, but if they play trumps to stop you then you'd like the trump play to come from West. West leads the ♥3, East plays the ♥K, and you win with the ♥A. You play a small ♣. If the defender who wins the ♣ doesn't play another trump then you can ruff your third ♣ in dummy. If the defender **DOES** play a trump, then you lose only one trump trick. You end up going down 1, which is pretty good.

Some contracts are impossible. So you just play to keep the damage as low as possible.

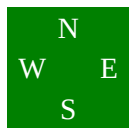
Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 6 5 3
♥ J 10 9 6 4
♦ A 6
♣ 9 8

♠ A 8 2
♥ K Q 5
♦ Q J 7 3
♣ Q 6 4



♠ K 7 4
♥ 8 7 2
♦ K 8 2
♣ J 10 7 5

♠ Q J 10
♥ A 3
♦ 10 9 5 4
♣ A K 3 2

West	North	East	South
	1♦	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥J			

You have three reasonable choices. You could bid 2♣, you could jump to 3♦, or you could jump to 2NT.

While all are reasonable, the jump to 2NT stands out as the most constructive by far. Partner bids 3NT and you pass.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥J.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥J.

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 3 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

If West has the ♠K then a finesse will gain you the two winners you need. However, if East has the ♠K then the finesse will gain you just one winner and you will be hoping for a 3-3 ♣ split for the other. While this is a possible Plan, there is a far better one.

Rather than chance the ♠ finesse, you should immediately start establishing your ♦s. This has the advantage of not giving the defense any **NEW** winners - they were always going to get their two high ♦s. So win the ♥A and play the ♦10. Somebody will take this and probably continue with a ♥. Take the ♥Q and play the ♦Q. Somebody will take this and probably continue with a ♥. Take the ♥K and then the rest of your winners. Maybe the ♣s will split 3-3 and give you an overtrick. And if you have assured the contract you MIGHT even try the ♠ finesse.

If you had taken an early ♠ finesse you would have gone down.

East would have won and played a ♥, removing your second stopper. When ♣s did not split 3-3 you would have been forced to try a ♦. East would win his ♦K and drive out the last ♥ stopper. Then West would be able to take the ♦A plus his established ♥s.

Board 6

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 5 3

♥ 4

♦ K 10 8 3

♣ K 10 2

♠ 8 7

♥ A 8 3

♦ 9 5 2

♣ Q 8 7 4 3



♠ 9 4

♥ 7 6 5 2

♦ Q 7 6 4

♣ A J 9

♠ A K 6 2

♥ K Q J 10 9

♦ A J

♣ 6 5

West	North	East	South
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Pass

2♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South

Lead: ♠Q

♦A and ruff your last ♠ with dummy's ♥A. Return to your hand with a trump. You will lose three minor suit cards and nothing else.

With 19 points and a 5-card ♥ suit you open 1♥.

Partner raises you to 2♥.

Partner's bid shows 6-10 points. If he has 6 it might be close, but otherwise you should have a game. You bid 4♥.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠Q.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 5

The three minor suit losers cannot be avoided, but the two ♠ losers can be ruffed in dummy. A small amount of caution is in order. Win the ♠K and play the ♠A. Ruff a ♠ with dummy's ♥8. East shows out but cannot over-ruff. Return to your hand with the

Some would go down on this hand when they ruffed the first ♠ with dummy's ♥3 and East over-ruffed. It is pretty clear that you should ruff with one of the higher cards, but sometimes the thought comes too late.